09

PART 9 OF 9

Apostolic Journeys

ACTS 13–28

From Syrian Antioch all the way to Rome: how the Gospel crossed the Mediterranean.



The World That Opened the Way for the Gospel

The Book of Acts tells how a small community in Jerusalem reached the capital of the empire within a few decades. From chapter thirteen, the main figure is Paul of Tarsus, who sets out from Syrian Antioch on a series of journeys, first with Barnabas, and later with Silas, Timothy, and Luke. The word "journey" hardly captures the scale: they covered thousands of kilometers by land and sea, through provinces where people spoke Greek, Latin, and the local languages of Anatolia.

These travels were made possible by the remarkable conditions of the age. The Pax Romana curbed banditry and war, Roman roads such as the Via Egnatia in Macedonia allowed travelers to cover dozens of kilometers a day, and sea lanes linked ports from Syria to Italy. Merchant ships sailed mostly from spring to autumn, since winter voyages could be deadly. Synagogues stood everywhere, where Paul would speak first, and Koine Greek was the common language in which the New Testament was written.

In this part you will visit twelve places: from Antioch, where the missionaries were sent out, through Cyprus, Anatolia, Macedonia, and Greece, to Ephesus, Caesarea, Malta, and Rome. Four maps show the routes of the first, second, and third journeys and the prisoner's voyage to the capital. The reconstructions are artistic interpretations based on archaeological knowledge, and distances are ap-

proximate. Imagine walking these roads with the travelers; geography helps us understand each of their choices, each obstacle, and each encounter.

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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The maps show routes and locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

MAP 9.1



The line shows the approximate direction of the journey: by sea to Cyprus, then to Pamphylia and overland into the heart of Anatolia. Cities are marked with dots, and mountains and sea are labeled separately.

The map shows that the first journey was made up of four distinct stages: a short crossing to Cyprus, a voyage to Pamphylia, a climb over the Taurus, and a trek along the Roman roads of Lycaonia. Notice how many cities lie close together on the plateau: Iconium, Lystra, and Derbe are only a few dozen kilometers apart. This allowed the missionaries to flee from one city to the next when opposition arose. They returned the same way, strengthening the communities by appointing elders.

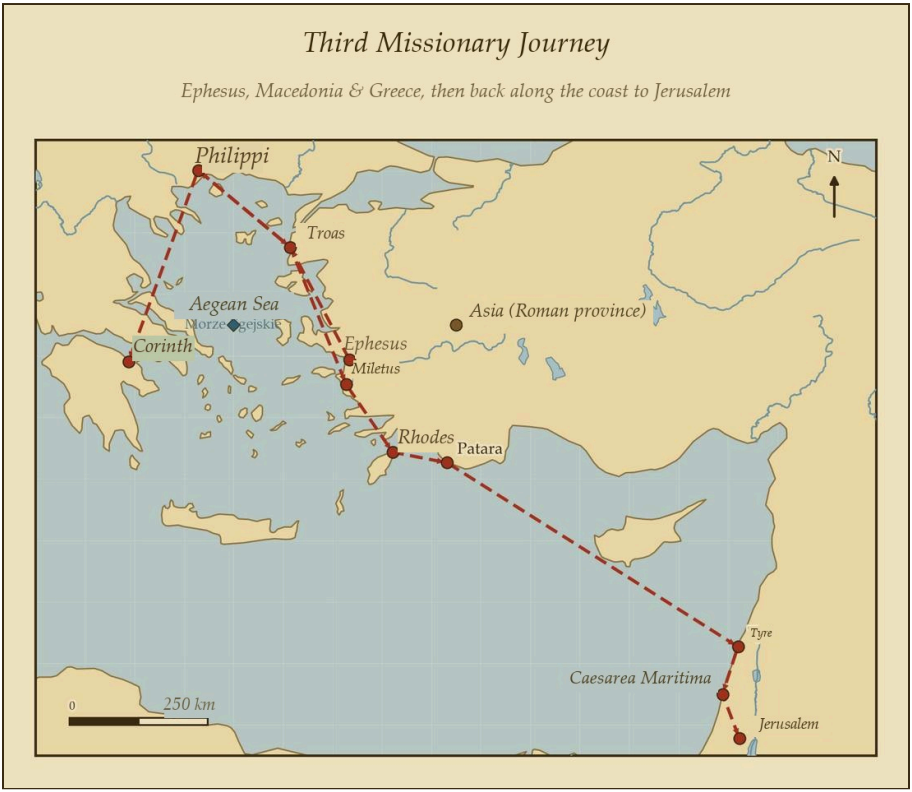
MAP 9.2



The line leads from Antioch through Cilicia and Lycaonia to Troas, then across the sea to Macedonia and on south to Greece. Green and blue labels mark regions and seas.

The second journey begins with an overland route through the Cilician Gates and ends in the heart of Greece. The crossing from Troas to Neapolis was a turning point, as the mission passed from Asia into Europe. The Via Egnatia led through Philippi and Thessalonica, and from there Paul went south to Berea, Athens, and Corinth. The map shows that he chose large commercial cities on roads and ports, from which the news spread further.

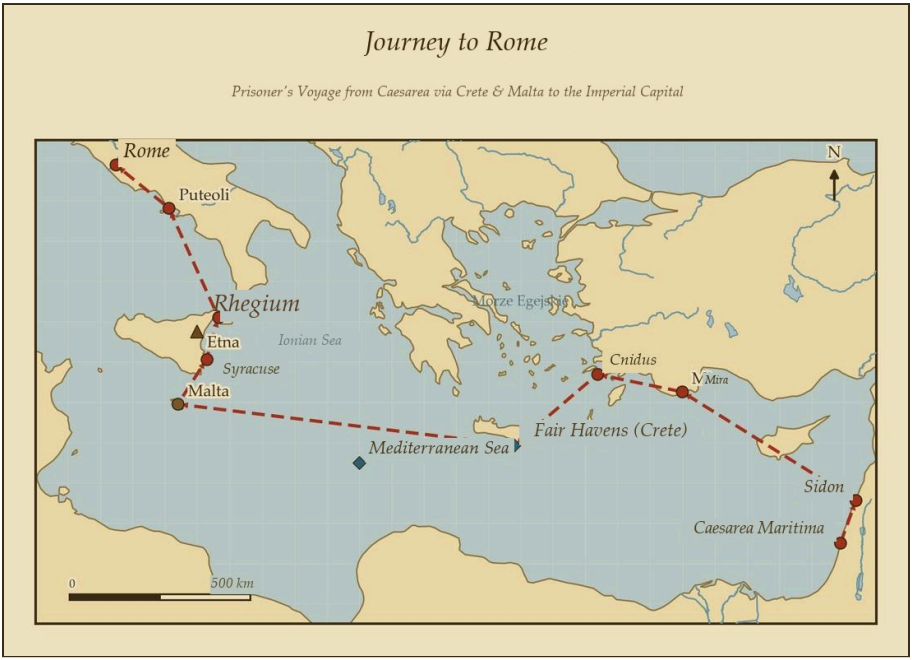
MAP 9.3



The first line shows the stay in Ephesus and the trip to Macedonia and Greece. The second shows the voyage from Philippi past the islands and along the coast of Asia Minor, and then on to Palestine.

On the third journey, Ephesus matters most, since Paul stayed there about two years. From there the Gospel spread throughout the province of Asia. Later Paul visited the communities of Macedonia and Greece, collecting a gift for the church in Jerusalem. The map also shows the turn toward Jerusalem: along the coasts, with a stop at Miletus, where he said farewell to the elders of Ephesus. It was a journey marked by concern for the unity of the Church.

MAP 9.4



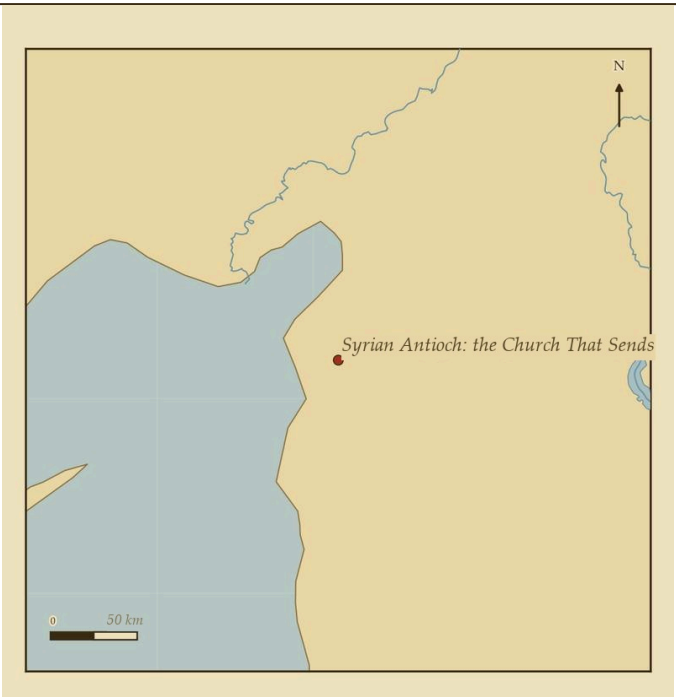
The line shows the approximate course of the voyage across the eastern and central Mediterranean, followed by the overland road from Puteoli to Rome. The stretch from Crete to Malta took place during a storm.

This voyage shows how dangerous sailing was outside the season. The ship began by hugging the coasts of Asia Minor, but off Crete the wind drove it out to open sea, toward Malta. Only in spring did the journey continue through Sicily to Italy. From Puteoli the road led overland along the Appian Way. The twelve places in this part form a single story: the Gospel travels from Jerusalem to the capital of the world.

01 Syrian Antioch – The Community That Sends

ACTS 11:19–26; 13:1–3

From the great city on the Orontes, the first missionaries set out.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the city stretched between the river and the slopes of Mount Silpius. The main avenue was lined with a colonnade where lanterns burned at night. The districts held temples, baths, and a theater, while in private homes groups of believers gathered. The smell of resin and olive oil hung over the harbor, and the voices of merchants from Syria, Greece, and Italy mingled on the pavement.

9.1 · SYRIAN ANTIOCH – THE COMMUNITY THAT SENDS · ACTS 11,19-26; 13,1-3

Antioch on the Orontes was one of the largest cities of the empire, alongside Rome and Alexandria. When refugees from Jerusalem reached Syria after the death of Stephen, they began to preach the Gospel to non-Jews as well. The community grew quickly, so Barnabas came from Jerusalem and then brought Saul over from Tarsus. For a whole year they taught a great crowd here, and it was in Antioch that the disciples were first called Christians. While the community was praying and fasting, the Holy Spirit directed them to set apart Barnabas and Saul for a new work, and after laying hands on them, they sent them on their way.

The city's location explains its role. Antioch lay in the valley of the Orontes River, about 30 km from the sea, and its port, Seleucia Pieria, opened the way to Cyprus and Asia Minor. Caravan routes led east to Mesopotamia, a coastal road led south to Palestine, and passes through the Amanus Mountains led north to Cilicia and Paul's hometown of Tarsus. A large Jewish community and many Greeks lived here, so the church was diverse from the start. This mixture of cultures became a natural starting point for the mission to the Gentiles.

FACTS

Distance from Antioch to Seleucia Pieria: approx. 25–30 km; to Tarsus: approx. 200 km.

02 Cyprus – Salamis and Paphos

ACTS 13:4–12

The first stop of the mission: Barnabas's island and the meeting with the proconsul.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the harbor of Paphos in the bright light of a Mediterranean morning. Wooden merchant ships with square sails are moored at a stone quay, and dockworkers load amphorae. On the hill in the background are the white facades of Roman villas and a temple. In the foreground, far from the viewer, a small group of travelers in cloaks walks along the quay.

From Seleucia Pieria the missionaries sailed to Cyprus, Barnabas's homeland, together with John Mark. In Salamis, the island's eastern port, they proclaimed the word in the synagogues. They then crossed the whole island to Paphos, the capital of the Roman province. The proconsul Sergius Paulus, an intelligent man, wanted to hear the word of God, but the Jewish magician Bar-Jesus, also called Elymas, opposed him. Saul, from then on called Paul, filled with the Holy Spirit, rebuked the magician, who lost his sight for a time. The proconsul, astonished at the teaching, believed. In this passage the name Paul appears for the first time.

Cyprus lies about 100 km from the coast of Syria, so it was a natural first leap across the sea. The island was famous for copper, a metal whose name comes from the island's own, as well as for timber and wine. The route from Salamis to Paphos ran along the southern coast and was about 150 km long. Paphos was the administrative capital and a center of the cult of Aphrodite, which made it a telling place for the first clash of the Gospel with the pagan world and a representative of Roman power. From here Paul sailed north, toward the coast of Pamphylia.

FACTS

Cyprus lies about 100 km from the coast of Syria; the Salamis–Paphos route is about 150 km.


N
Cyprus: Salamis & Paphos
0
50 km

03 Pisidian Antioch – Synagogue and Rejection

ACTS 13:13–52

In the mountains of Pisidia, Paul gives his first great speech and turns to the Gentiles.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a high mountain city in cool, clear light. In the marketplace stand Roman buildings of pale stone, and above them rises a hill with the sanctuary of the god Men. In the distance, on a path leading out of the gate, two wanderers in traveling cloaks can be seen. Behind them, snow still lies on the peaks of the Taurus.

9.3 · PISIDIAN ANTIOCH – SYNAGOGUE AND REJECTION · ACTS 13,13-52

From Paphos the missionaries sailed to Pamphylia and reached Perga, where John Mark returned to Jerusalem. Paul and Barnabas went on through the mountains to Pisidian Antioch. On the Sabbath they entered the synagogue, and after the reading of the Law and the Prophets they were asked for a word of encouragement. Paul recounted the history of Israel from the Exodus to David and proclaimed that God had raised up a Savior, Jesus. The listeners asked to hear more, and the following Sabbath nearly the whole city gathered. When jealous opponents objected, Paul announced that he was turning to the Gentiles, and the word spread throughout the region, until the missionaries were driven out.

The road from Perga in Pamphylia to Antioch led through the Taurus Mountains and was about 160 km long. The city stood at an altitude of about 1,200 m above sea level, so the climate was harsher than by the sea, and the journey was arduous and dangerous because of bandits and mountain passes. Antioch was a Roman colony founded by Augustus, set on an important road leading west to Iconium, so news quickly traveled onward. For this reason Paul's expulsion did not halt evangelization: he went along the same road to the next cities.

FACTS

City elevation: approx. 1,200 m above sea level; road from Perga: approx. 160 km through the Taurus.


N
Pisidian Antioch: Synagogue & Rejection
0
50 km

04 Lystra – Healing and Stoning

ACTS 14:6–20

A lame man healed, a crowd crying "gods," and stones.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a modest town on a steppe plateau, with a few stone buildings around a small marketplace. Above it rises a hill with the ruins of an older settlement, and beyond stretch wheat fields and sheep pastures. From the marketplace, near the temple of Zeus, sacrificial smoke rises, and in the distance the silhouettes of the Taurus range can be seen.

9.4 · LYSTRA – HEALING AND STONING · ACTS 14:6–20

After being driven out of Iconium, Paul and Barnabas reached Lycaonia, to the city of Lystra. There Paul saw a man lame from birth who was listening to his teaching, and told him to stand up. When he rose and began to walk, the crowd cried out in the Lycaonian language that the gods had come down to men, and called Barnabas Zeus and Paul Hermes. The priest had already brought wreaths and oxen, but the apostles tore their clothes and stopped the sacrifice. Soon Jews arrived from Antioch and Iconium, won over the crowd, stoned Paul, and dragged him outside the city. The disciples gathered around him, and he got up and went back into the city.

Lystra lay on the plateau of central Anatolia, southwest of Iconium, about 35–40 km away. It was an insignificant Roman colony where people still spoke the local Lycaonian language, which explains the crowd's reaction without understanding the apostles' Greek. The traditional location points to a hill near present-day Hatunsaray. Timothy came from Lystra and joined Paul on the second journey. The next day Paul set out for Derbe, which shows how close together the cities along the Roman road lay.

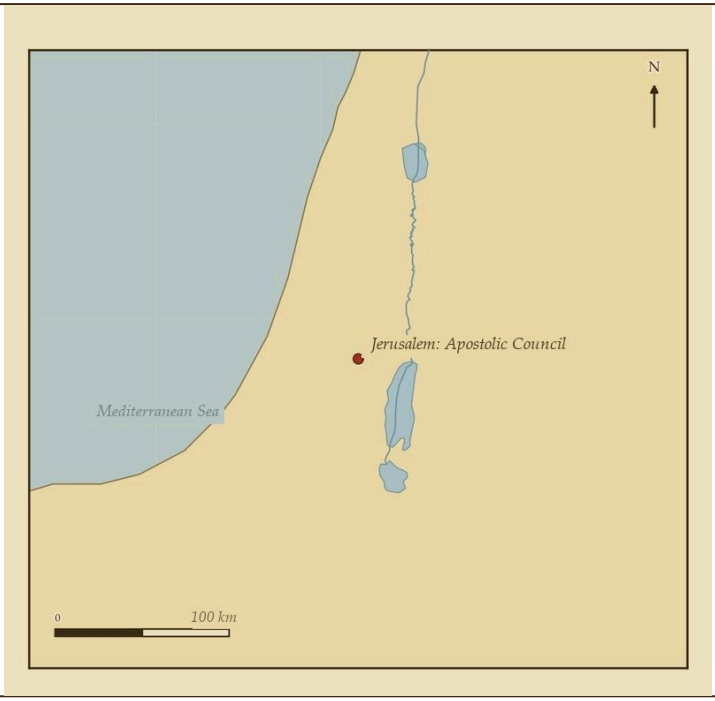
FACTS

Distance Iconium–Lystra: approx. 35–40 km; traditional location near present-day Hatunsaray.

05 Jerusalem – The Apostolic Council

ACTS 15:1–35

The first assembly of the Church decides whether Gentiles must adopt the Law of Moses.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows Jerusalem in the mid-first century: limestone houses on the hills, the vast Temple complex with its gleaming plating, and the narrow streets of the Upper City. The assembly meets in the modest hall of a house, where men in plain cloaks sit on benches and the morning light streams through an open window.

After the return from the first journey to Antioch, a dispute arose: some newcomers from Judea claimed that without circumcision there is no salvation. Paul and Barnabas therefore went to Jerusalem, where the apostles and elders gathered to examine the matter. Peter recalled that God had given the Spirit to the Gentiles as well, Paul and Barnabas told of the signs, and James proposed a resolution in line with Scripture. They decided not to burden the Gentiles with the Law, asking only for a few practices that would ease fellowship. A letter was sent with trusted messengers, Judas and Silas, and the community in Antioch received it with joy.

The road from Antioch to Jerusalem was about 500 km long and ran through Phoenicia and Samaria, so travelers could tell along the way of the conversion of the Gentiles. The City of David stood at an altitude of about 750 m above sea level and drew pilgrims from all over the world. The council is traditionally dated to about AD 49. The discussion shows that decisions were made together, in a place rooted in salvation history, but with attention to the mission's experience in distant lands. This meeting opened the way for Paul's further journeys.

FACTS

Road from Antioch to Jerusalem: approx. 500 km; date of the council: approx. AD 49.

06 Philippi – Lydia, Prison, and Earthquake

ACTS 16:8–40

The first community in Europe is born by a river and in a prison cell.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a Roman colony at the foot of a hill, with the broad Via Egnatia passing through the middle of the city. On one side is the forum with its colonnade, on the other the acropolis with a theater set into the slope. Outside the walls, by a stream in the greenery, a few women sit in a group, and in the distance two figures of travelers approach them.

In Troas, Paul saw in a dream a Macedonian begging for help, so the group, which now included Luke, sailed past Samothrace to Neapolis, and from there went to Philippi. On the Sabbath they went outside the city to the river, where women were praying. Lydia, a seller of purple from Thyatira, opened her heart to the word and was baptized with her household. Later Paul drove a spirit out of a slave girl, her owners accused the missionaries before the magistrates, and they were flogged and thrown into prison. At midnight an earthquake opened the doors, and the jailer, instead of killing himself, asked about the way of salvation and was baptized.

Philippi lay on the Via Egnatia, the main Roman road linking the Adriatic with the Bosporus, about 15 km from the seaport of Neapolis. The city was a Roman colony settled by veterans of the civil wars, so its residents proudly emphasized their citizenship. The area was famous for its gold mines and fertile plain. The crossing of the Aegean Sea from Troas took only two days, which eased the mission's passage from Asia to Europe. It was here that the Church arose to which Paul later wrote a letter from prison.

FACTS

Distance Philippi–Neapolis: approx. 15 km; Neapolis–Troas via Samothrace: approx. 2 days' sailing.


N
Philippi & Prison; Winter at Nicopolis
0
50 km

07 Athens – The Areopagus

ACTS 17:16–34

In the intellectual center of the world, Paul speaks of the unknown God.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the rocky summit of the Areopagus, steps cut into the rock, and a group of men in cloaks, their backs to the viewer, listening to a speaker. Behind them rises the Acropolis with the Parthenon in bright light, below the agora with its porticoes bustles, and a few birds circle above the rooftops of the city.

9.7 · ATHENS – AREOPAGUS · ACTS 17:16–34

After Thessalonica and Berea, from where Paul had to flee because of unrest, he reached Athens alone. Seeing a city full of statues, he spoke in the synagogue and in the agora with Jews, God-fearers, and philosophers. The Epicureans and Stoics brought him to the Areopagus, where he presented God the Creator, who does not dwell in temples made by human hands. He used the altar "to an unknown God" and quotations from Greek poets, but the word about the resurrection drew scorn. The believers remained few, yet among them were Dionysius the Areopagite and a woman named Damaris.

Athens lies about 80 km east of Corinth, between the Saronic Gulf and the mountains of Hymettus and Pentelicus. The hill of the Areopagus rises to about 115 m, right next to the Acropolis, which is about 156 m, so the speaker could see the symbols of the city's religion: the Parthenon and the temples. Although the famous classical period had passed, Athens was still renowned as a center of learning, and its agora served as the public forum. This place demanded a new language of proclamation from the apostle: he did not begin with Moses, but with the questions that preoccupied the Greeks.

FACTS

Height of the Areopagus: approx. 115 m above sea level; distance Athens–Corinth: approx. 80 km.


N
Aegean Sea
Athens: Areopagus
0
50 km

08 Corinth – City of Two Ports

ACTS 18:1–18

A year and a half in Corinth, where Paul works and founds a great community.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a wealthy trading port with a lively marketplace. Above the city looms the mighty rock of Acrocorinth with the ruins of a temple on its summit. In workshops, craftsmen sew tents of goat hair, and on the pavement stand stalls with copper vessels, fruit, and fabrics from all over the Mediterranean.

After Athens Paul arrived in Corinth, where he met the Jews Aquila and Priscilla, who had been expelled from Rome, and stayed with them because they shared the same trade. Every Sabbath he reasoned in the synagogue, and when opposition grew after Silas and Timothy arrived, he turned to the Gentiles and moved to the house of Titius Justus. Even the synagogue ruler, Crispus, was converted. After a vision that strengthened him, Paul stayed here about a year and a half. Accused before the proconsul Gallio, he was released, because the Roman saw no crime in the case.

Corinth lay on an isthmus about 6 km wide that joined the Peloponnese to the mainland, and it had two ports: Lechaion on the Gulf of Corinth and Cenchreae on the Saronic Gulf. Small ships were dragged across the isthmus on a special roadway, and all goods passed through the city. Because of this it was rich, cosmopolitan, and known for its immorality. The hill of Acrocorinth rose to about 575 m. Paul wrote several letters from Corinth, and from here he sailed for Ephesus, taking Aquila and Priscilla with him.

FACTS

Width of the Isthmus of Corinth: approx. 6 km; Paul's stay: approx. 18 months.

09 Ephesus – The Artemision and the Theater

ACTS 19:1–40

Paul's longest stay: teaching in the school of Tyrannus and the silversmiths' riot.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a marble harbor street with a colonnade, leading toward an enormous theater set into the hillside. Merchants, pilgrims, and craftsmen crowd the street. In the distance, on the plain, the white mass of the Artemision gleams with its forest of columns, and behind it stretches a line of mountains.

Paul came to Ephesus on his third journey, first meeting disciples of John the Baptist, who were baptized in the name of Jesus, and the Spirit came upon them. For three months he spoke in the synagogue, and when he met opposition, he moved to the school of Tyrannus, where he taught daily for two years. Healings took place here, and converts burned magic books worth a fortune. When the silversmith Demetrius, who made small shrines of Artemis, saw his profits fall, he stirred up a riot. The crowd rushed to the theater and shouted for about two hours, until the city clerk calmed the people.

Ephesus lay at the mouth of the Cayster River, by the sea, and was the capital of the Roman province of Asia. Its Artemision was counted among the Seven Wonders of the ancient world. The theater on the slope of Mount Pion held about 25,000 spectators, and a straight harbor street, the Arcadiane, led to the quay. Because it stood at the junction of land and sea routes, the city was an excellent center for spreading the teaching. For this reason people from nearby cities such as Colossae and Laodicea heard the Gospel, although Paul himself never went there.

FACTS

Theater capacity: approx. 25,000 spectators; Paul's stay: approx. 2–3 years.


N
Ephesus: Artemision & Theater
0
50 km

10 Caesarea Maritima – A Prisoner Before the Governors

ACTS 23:23–26:32

Two years in Herod's palace: Felix, Festus, and King Agrippa.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the governor's palace built on a promontory above the Mediterranean, with colonnades and a pool open to the waves. Beyond it can be seen a semicircular hippodrome, a theater, and the great harbor of Sebastos with its lighthouse. Soldiers in red cloaks guard the steps leading to the hall of hearings.

After his arrest in Jerusalem and a plot to kill him, the Roman tribune sent Paul under heavy escort to Caesarea, the seat of the governor Felix. There Paul defended himself against his accusers from Jerusalem, and Felix put off the verdict, hoping for a bribe. After two years his successor Festus, wishing to win favor with the Jews, proposed a trial in Jerusalem. As a Roman citizen, Paul appealed to the emperor. Later, before King Agrippa II and his sister Bernice, he told of his conversion, and Agrippa judged that an innocent man could have been set free.

Caesarea Maritima, built by Herod the Great around 22–10 BC, was the capital of the Roman province of Judea and had one of the largest artificial harbors of antiquity, Sebastos. It lay about 100 km from Jerusalem, so a prisoner could be transported in a single night under the escort of several hundred soldiers. From here the port made it easy to sail to Phoenicia, Asia Minor, and Italy. Thus the appeal to the emperor meant that Paul would set out by ship from the same coast that the Gospel had left in the direction of the world.

FACTS

Distance Caesarea–Jerusalem: approx. 100 km; Paul's imprisonment: approx. 2 years.

11 Malta – The Shipwreck

ACTS 27:1–28:10

After a storm lasting about two weeks, the ship is wrecked off the island's shore.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the rocky shore of northern Malta at dawn after a storm. A wooden ship with a broken mast is stuck among the waves, and on the beach the shipwrecked gather around a fire. From a distance, people in simple robes approach, carrying blankets and wood. The sky is heavy with clouds, and the sea is still foaming.

Paul set out for Rome under the escort of the centurion Julius on ships from Caesarea, and after changing at Myra to an Alexandrian grain ship. At Crete, in Fair Havens, Paul warned against sailing further, but the sailors set out, looking for a better port. The wind Euroclydon struck and for about two weeks tossed the ship about on the open sea. Paul, supported by a vision of an angel, assured everyone they would be saved. The ship ran aground, and 276 people reached shore by swimming or on planks. On Malta, while warming himself by the fire, Paul shook a viper off his hand, and later healed Publius's father.

Malta lies about 90 km from Sicily and is about 27 km long, so finding it in a storm was a matter of luck. Tradition places the wreck in St. Paul's Bay on the north of the island. The inhabitants, called barbarians in the text because they did not speak Greek, received the castaways warmly. In winter sailing usually stopped, so the party spent three months here, then set out on an Alexandrian ship bearing the emblem of the Dioscuri. This allowed the journey to Rome to be completed in spring.

FACTS

Malta lies about 90 km from Sicily; length of the island: approx. 27 km; shipwrecked: 276 people.


N
Malta: Shipwreck
0
50 km

12 Rome – A House on the Appian Way and the End of the Road

ACTS 28:11–31

The road through Syracuse and Puteoli ends in the capital of the empire.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the paving of the Appian Way shaded by pines, along which a group of travelers makes its way among tombs and villas. In the distance, on the horizon, the roofs of Rome's temples and aqueducts gleam. In one of the city's alleys stands a modest rented house, reached by narrow steps, and a few guests wait in front of it.

After three months on Malta, the travelers set sail on an Alexandrian ship, stopped for three days at Syracuse, sailed around to Rhegium, and after one day of a south wind reached Puteoli. There they met brothers and were invited to stay for a week. From Puteoli the road led toward Rome, and believers came out to meet Paul as far as the Forum of Appius and the Three Taverns. Paul thanked God and took courage. In Rome he was allowed to live in a rented house, under guard of a soldier. For two years he welcomed all who came and proclaimed the Kingdom of God without hindrance.

Puteoli was the main port for grain from Alexandria, and from there the Appian Way led to Rome, about 230 km of road that travelers covered in a few days. Earlier believers, such as Aquila and Priscilla, had built a community in the capital, to which Paul addressed the Letter to the Romans. The city had about a million inhabitants and was at the center of the world, so Paul's very presence here symbolizes the Gospel reaching the "ends of the earth" of which Jesus had spoken. The Book of Acts ends with an open scene: the teaching goes on.

FACTS

Road Puteoli–Rome via the Appian Way: approx. 230 km; Paul's house arrest: approx. 2 years.

Questions for Reflection

1. Why did Syrian Antioch, rather than Jerusalem, become the base for the mission to the Gentiles, and what does this say about the role of the community in sending out missionaries?

2. How did Paul adapt his manner of speaking to his listeners in the synagogue in Pisidian Antioch and on the Areopagus in Athens, and what can you learn from this when talking with people of different views?

3. What geographical factors, such as Roman roads, ports, and the sailing season, eased or hindered Paul's travels, and which of them can be seen most clearly on the maps in this part?